Goryeo

The Goryeo Dynasty ruled the Korean peninsula between 918 and 1392 CE. This is where the modern English name Korea originates from. Wang Geon established Songdo (modern day Kaesong) as the capital for his new dynasty and declared himself as king. His name was changed to King Taejo after his death when he became known as the “Great Founder”. Even in its early days, the kingdom caught the attention of various other states that were looking to expand their territories. The Khitan attempted to invade the state twice only to be completely defeated in 1033 CE. The kingdom eventually constructed a fortified wall that extended across the north to protect its borders.

Goryeo began to prosper and flourish such that Songdo had more than a thousand stores alone. In 996 CE, Goryeo began to mint its own coins and the unbyong silver vases were created in 1101 CE. They were used as currency because they displayed the official seals set by the government. Portable metal printing and the old woodblock printing methods were further developed during this time. Buddhism became the major religion and numerous religious texts were authored by the Koreans. Kim Pu-sik penned the “History of the Three Kingdoms” in 1145 CE, which became very popular at its time.

However, there was a darker side to the prosperity Goryeo experienced and it wasn’t long before corruption and greed spread throughout the state. Rebellions occurred in 1126 and then again in 1135. Although the rebellions were quickly crushed, the people remained unhappy. It was during the reign of King Uijong that they began to openly criticize the funds being spent to construct extravagant palaces and water parks for the king’s amusement. In 1170, the military overthrew the king and replaced him with his brother Myeongjong. Myeongjong was essentially a puppet king who was not able to govern his people well. The country became swamped with internal fighting that lasted for decades. Various rebellions, assassinations and uprisings occurred that mark this period in history.